In Our Time

Contents

Wretched Brats · 1/4 . . . 3
The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum . . . 3
Wretched Brats · 2/4 . . . 5
Dr. Papper . . . 7
To the New World . . . 8
Chicago Rescue . . . 10
Sharpodonty and Black Wine · 1/2 . . . 11
Wall Street Journal . . . 13
Sharpodonty and Black Wine · 2/2 . . . 13
The Rosa Killer · 1/2 . . . 14
Intermission . . . 14
The Rosa Killer · 2/2 . . . 16
Scorched Woods . . . 18
Trail ① Afflatus Relations . . . 19
Trail ② News . . . 19
Trail ③ An Unknown Traveller I . . . 20
Druvis III · 1/2 . . . 20
Trail ① Incantation Upgrade . . . 21
Incredible Unicorn . . . 21
Druvis III · 2/2 . . . 21
Security Carnival . . . 23
Trail ① Hello, Ms. Sonetto . . . 25
Trail ② Tactic to Disarm . . . 25
The Origin Butterfly . . . 25
Trail ① To Another Castle . . . 26
Trail ② Critter's Sheet . . . 28
Charge Baby, Charge! · 1/2 . . . 28
Matilda's School Report . . . 29
Charge Baby, Charge! · 2/2 . . . 29
Appetizers · 1/2 . . . 30
Trail ① The Strange Thing in the Labyrinth . . . 33
Trail ② Chat in front of the Bar . . . 33

Appetizers · 2/2 . . . 33
The Rattenfanger . . . 34
Trail ① Prepare for the Ultimate . . . 36
Trail ② An Unknown Traveller Ⅱ . . . 36
The Critter in a Coma . . . 36
The Eye of the Storm . . . 37
Trail ① Poem . . . 39
Trail ① Tuning O' One . . . 39
Underground Labyrinth . . . 39
Heaven Apostles · 1/2 . . . 41
How Many Older Sisters Does Schneider Have? . . . 44
Heaven Apostles · 2/2 . . . 46
Trail ① Garden Scissors . . . 46
Trail ② The Ignored Nameplate . . . 46

Wretched Brats · 1/4

1ST-01

In Our Time

Wretched Brats

Little Giant Tommy: P-p-people come out from the suitcase?!

Pumpkin-Head Jame: Agh, it's a weirdo's case! She knows dark magic. Run!

Vertin: This is my suitcase. Please give it back to me.

Little Giant Tommy: No! Don't touch me! Imma give it to the officer!

Pumpkin-Head Jame: Haha! Kiss my ass! You damn Basilisk losers!

APPLe: ... When a pirate meets robbers? Robbing is not a good behavior that you kids should learn.

Pumpkin-Head Jame: That apple is talking!

Pumpkin-Head Jame: Ew!! Throw rocks at it!!

APPLe: Aww ...!

APPLe: Looks like the generation we met is not quite friendly.

Vertin: If they shake the suitcase like this, Regulus will probably fall apart.

Vertin: Mr. APPLe, I need your help.

APPLe: My pleasure. This APPLe will shed some light on justice for them—well, won't violate *the Declaration of the Rights of the Child*.

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

小径

Now those little brats are knocked out. You noticed that old gum sticking to the bottom of their shoes, like crushed leeches.

Choices

1. What color is the gum?
2. What happened to the gum?
3. What gum? I don't care!

Branch 1

> Having been chewed for long, it took on the light amber color that the carbohydrate gum should have. Some folds were cyan. It's most likely mint-flavored.
>
> The sales champion of mint gum is the bubble gum machine near Wrigley Field. When a crazy game ends, there's always someone who needs something to chew in the mouth in order to take out the anger over the defeat.
>
> But ... Hey. Haven't you noticed yet? That wonderful mix of particles in the chewing gum base that's been squeezed into lumps?
>
> The off-white sand. The synthetic waxed elastic fiber. In the South Bank, there is only one place where such a politically symbolic floor is laid—St. Pavlov Foundation.

Branch 2

> Tragedy. A sympathetic encounter. It has fulfilled its mission cautiously and conscientiously. But clearly, no one cares.

I dare say it's the most popular mint gum now. When the Chicagoans lost their rights to get drunk, they could only turn to this nasty upstart stuff.

The sales champion is the bubble gum machine near Wrigley Field. The old gum on the kids' soles also comes from there.

Some gravel mixed into the squeezed gum base. The off-white sand. The synthetic waxed elastic fiber. In the South Bank, there is only one place where such a politically symbolic floor is laid—St. Pavlov Foundation.

Branch 3

Who does? I'm very glad that we are on the same page on this.

Describing an abandoned carbohydrate gum won't give anyone pleasure. So, let's skip to the next subject—Have you noticed the gravel mixed into the gum base?

The off-white sand. The synthetic waxed elastic fiber. In the South Bank, there is only one place where such a politically symbolic floor is laid—St. Pavlov Foundation.

It's very lively here in the square, just like every day in the past. Speculators, who advocate mankind supremacy, are trying to get the attention of the Foundation through demonstrations.

They are on the same side as the Foundation, but the Foundation has no intention to treat these protesters as allies and give them what they want. They even sent a little girl to go through the motions as a perfunctory response.

Choices

1. Little girls? An excellent topic.

Yes. Yes. No one will ever ignore them. They are honey-colored. They are the morning sun in California. They are the dazzling spot on the doe that you'll never catch.

For those hypocritical politicians, the little girls are the delicacies that they would drool over. Luckily, this little girl is not one of their prey.

She is nervous but not panicked. She doesn't seem to be good at dealing with these slick "politicians." The mission capsule of the Foundation grew hot in her tightly clutched fist.

And on the other side of the square, another little girl in a black suit is looking over here gloomily. She stood by the Foundation's air outlet, the best place for her.

The position that is too marginal to be further marginalized. That's the best portrayal of the second-generation immigrants in the 20th century.

Choices

1. Tell me about that Foundation girl.

2. Who's the girl in a black suit?

Branch 3.1

She is the good girl you already know. Orange hair. When she's deep in thought, she turns her pen like a nimble ball in a magician's hand.

She is puzzled at the guys shouting around her. But there's light in her eyes, as if she's expecting something nice.

Is it because of the next task packed in the mission capsule? Or the people she is going to meet?

Her cheeks are a little rosy now. The thing in her hands was loosened too.

Branch 3.2

She's someone you will know in the future.

Now she shudders and shivers, like a cricket desperate for shelter. She's looking for an eave or a piece of rubble in the "Storm."

Her figure might be frail, but her eyes are filled with cold anger. Maybe she had been rejected just now, or even insulted. She walked up to the square center with firm step, like a warrior.

She had to perform another task she didn't like.

At this moment, the capsule in the hand of the ad hoc representative of the Foundation dropped under the push of the crowd.

—This is a good chance.

She feels a hot wind from Africa blow towards Trapani. Then, the whole of Sicily becomes dry, warm, and comes alive. The air smells like tropical corals and wild oranges.

That wind is never supposed to be part of this cold winter. But the warm vibe lingering and dancing in her mind reminds her to live on.

She used to be desperate.

Though all she has been through was failure after failure, her vigorous vitality won't fade away, at least not now.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Wretched Brats · 2/4

1ST-01

Vertin: Hide it in the tree hole this time. It shouldn't be that easy to be found.

APPLe: The situation of the arcanists 40 years ago looked much worse than ours. At least we can still talk to the human.

Vertin: The subculture movement has indeed changed the social status of some arcanists. While in the 1920s ... there are still many injustices.

Vertin: ... Mr. APPLe, how long will it take for the suitcase to be completely invisible?

APPLe: Thirty minutes. This APPLe is still waiting for the right solar altitude.

APPLe: You can meet with Regulus first. This APPLe is afraid that in order to have some fun, she might ...

APPLe: Ahem ... In order to relieve the boredom, she might make you troubles.

Choices

1. Okay.

Vertin: Regulus?

Vertin: There is only echo.

Vertin: And no sign of Regulus.

Vertin: No one's here. The light is off. Did she go to another room?

Vertin: Someone is singing at the lake. The sound carries into the room faintly.

Regulus: Haha ... ♪

Vertin: Regulus! Why are you there?

Vertin: The outside scenery keeps changing and changing ...

Vertin: What has remained unchanged for ages is the lake and an old spinning wheel.

Regulus: *sobs* ... The records ... Don't nick my records ...

Vertin: ...!

Vertin: Her voice doesn't sound right.

Vertin: I should go and take a look.

Vertin: This is where Vertin has never been.

Vertin: Regulus! Regulus!

Vertin: I can't see her at all ... The fog is getting thicker ...

Vertin: Vertin goes closer and finds half a spinning wheel in the middle of the lake, with strange threads on it.

Vertin: ... The line is two-dimensional?

The water rises.

Vertin: More and more water rises.

Vertin: The ground is covered with rainwater from the "Storm." Incredibly, the water has no weight, or humidity. It just flows slowly and quietly, like time.

Vertin: Time ...

Vertin: I seem to have seen this ... It's ... I ...

Vertin: The line in her hand, technically the line-like thing in her hand which cannot be felt in any way, has gradually formed a path in her sight.

Vertin: And someone is going to be invited over.

Vertin: ... Hm?

Sonetto: ... Timekeeper?! Yes! Ahh, ahem, I ... I'm just thinking about how to find you.

Sonetto: May I ask where is this place?

Sonetto: Did you use the advanced arcane skill "Aferoj Around," No. 000262603100008, to send me over?

Sonetto: No, it should not be this ...

Vertin: Sonetto?! Why are ... Is it because I touched ... that line?

Regulus: *grunting*

Regulus: The fog lifts and reveals Regulus. Now, she is sleeping soundly with a rock in her arms.

Sonetto: Regulus?!

Sonetto: Madam Z is right! She said Regulus was with you!

Vertin: What?!

Sonetto: Regulus, she ... Hmm? She seems to be asleep ... well ...

Sonetto: Umm ... I am also a bit like ... quite dizzy ...?

Vertin: Why did you all black out?

Vertin: What happened? I don't seem to be affected ...

Vertin: On the lake, the spinning wheel is still shimmering.

Vertin: Hmm ...

Vertin: I should come back and check again later.

Choices

1. Take them away first.

Vertin: The sound of water is left behind her.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Dr. Papper

1ST-02

Dr.Papper

Indeed, this lake is surrounded by a mysterious fog. Mr. APPLe tries to figure it out, but almost falls into a coma.

The spinning wheel has been on standby for casting some arcane skill.

APPLe: Ms. Vertin! They all wake up!

APPLe: However ...

APPLe: Sonetto found Regulus immediately ... They're at a standoff in the lobby.

Vertin: ...!

Vertin: I'm coming.

Vertin: You are awake ... How do you feel? Any discomfort?

Regulus: ...

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: Timekeeper ... you made it!

Sonetto: I heard that you caught ... no, you gained the trust of Regulus ...

Sonetto: When I returned to the research center, the committee informed me that Regulus would join the Foundation as our colleague.

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: I am here to convey the committee's commendation and your next mission.

Sonetto: I did not expect that you would just summon me ... In the future, if possible, I hope you could show me the incantation. I would also like to learn it!

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: Regulus, we are very glad to have you!

Sonetto: However, you need to go to the Foundation and the Scientific Computing Center first to complete the registration process.

Sonetto: As an arcanist talent rated S, we will provide you with the best equipment for scientific research.

Choices

1. This is a mistake.

2. Congratulations!

Branch 1

Regulus: Yes, it's a mistake. A bloody huge mistake!!

Regulus: Which star said she was ever going to join the Foundation? Ridiculous! Is this Pirate really so easily recruited?

Branch 2

Regulus: Hey, congratulations for what!

Regulus: That wasn't the deal we made!

Shared continuation

Regulus: The institution Vertin told me is a place where the "Storm" can be avoided, free use of arcane skills is guaranteed, and Dr. Papper is even free for 365 days!

Vertin: ...

APPLe: Exactly. If it is a place full of serious old men, Regulus must not be interested in it. Sorry for this APPLe's interruption.

Sonetto: What ...?! No, no no! The Foundation is definitely not a place for serious old men!

Sonetto: That ... That's where Vertin and I grew up. And there are many other interesting people like us ... Ahem! Young people.

Sonetto: Vertin, don't just stand there. Talk to them. Explain that.

APPLe: Who knew Ms. Sonetto could be so panicked.

APPLe: Well, at least the Foundation is not that horrible at all.

Sonetto: ... I should have more training.

Over shoes, over boots.

Vertin: Let me explain. Regulus, APPLe, what I invited you to join before is ... the St. Pavlov Foundation.

Vertin: As for Dr. Papper, I think Sonetto will find a way.

Sonetto: ... I will definitely make an application to the administration.

Regulus: *tuts* Hah ...

Regulus: Fine. For the sake of 365 days of free drink, I'll join you.

Regulus: It shouldn't take too long to go through the procedures, right? I've got a bunch of belongings to pack up. Vertin, you ... come and help me!

Choices

1. Sure.

Regulus: Three of them leave the room.

TO BE CONTINUED...

To the New World

1ST-03

To the New World

Vertin: I'm sorry ...

APPLe: Turns out the Foundation doesn't fully trust you. Just like you don't trust them.

APPLe: You acted privately without their knowledge, but they were still able to foresee the outcome.

APPLe: If you don't mind, please tell us the stories from the past. After all, that's where our captain is leaving for.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: The Foundation is currently the charity that can provide the best treatment for arcanists. There is no doubt about it.

Vertin: Every few years, the Foundation selects talented arcanists from children around the world.

Vertin: They go to orphanages and admonition centers, and even fish out unique ones from the prisons in detention centers.

Vertin: I was also one of them. Since I can remember, I know it very well that I am alone.

Vertin: Until 1999, when the first "Storm" came ...

Vertin: I ... I seem to see my mother.

Regulus: So you have a mother!

Vertin: ...

Vertin: ... I was not sure.

Vertin: All of us ... our memories of 1999 are blurred. I can only remember that she was placed on a laboratory bed, surrounded by many medical staff.

Vertin: They shouted her name and mine. ... And I can't remember anything else. Later, no matter how hard I tried to ask, the official answer I got was always "No such person".

Vertin: I have no intention to make enemies of the Foundation ... As I said, I just want to find out the truth ... all the truth about 1999.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I know what you said to Sonetto just now is expedient. I can still help you get out of here.

Regulus: *tuts* Never mind.

Regulus: Think about it. If they can detect the whereabouts of the first one, then of course they can find the second and third. ... In that case, it never ends, does it?

Regulus: You can't send all your partners away!

Vertin: So you mean ...

Choices

1. You will join me?

2. You have other thoughts?

Branch 1

Regulus: Humph! I won't lose anything ... to go with you. Just don't forget the great kindness of the Pirate.

Branch 2

Regulus: You betcha!

Regulus: If I sneak away ... am I saying that I'm just a chicken ... a coward!

Shared continuation

APPLe: ...

Regulus: Anyway, I've considered carefully. In this world, the "Storm" never stops. How could real "freedom" exist?!

Regulus: Since I would be inevitably "reversed" wherever I go, *tuts* better to sneak into the Foundation and investigate!

Regulus: By the way, you've got the best research devices ...

Regulus: Wow ha ha, it's gonna be so much fun! I have a lot of little things to study.

APPLe: Hmm, I see ...

APPLe: In that case, this APPLe respects the Captain's decision. In the current volatile situation, it is also more beneficial for us to join the official institution.

APPLe: The Foundation and we, after all, are not on the opposite sides in the first place.

Choices

1. Thank you.

Regulus: It's okay. Don't bother. Since you told me about the "Storm", I am more or less excited. ... Ahem!

Vertin: Then come back as soon as you finish the registration. The Foundation is open to public, but it's still heavily guarded.

APPLe: Indeed. Back in yesterday we were still wanted pirates ... We'll have to be careful on this trip.

Regulus: Huh? You don't have to go with me.

Regulus: I've actually got something very important for you to keep. Mr. APPLe, come here.

APPLe: ... Yes? Is there anything this APPLe could help with?

Regulus: Regulus and APPLe start whispering.

Sonetto: Excuse me.

Sonetto: Could I talk to you for a second, Timekeeper?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Chicago Rescue

1ST-04

Chicago Rescue

Sonetto: I did not expect that there is such a big place in your suitcase. I never knew it before.

Choices

1. Huh? You didn't call me "Timekeeper"?

2. Not too late to know now.

Branch 1

Sonetto: So-sorry! I got carried away!

Branch 2

Sonetto: You are right. I am very happy to be invited over.

Shared continuation

Sonetto: I ...

Sonetto: I got promoted.

Sonetto: The committee recommended me ... to help you as the chief assistant.

Sonetto: The scope of your responsibilities has also increased. You will be in charge of all the investigations on the "Storm" and Manus Vindictae. The authorities will provide us with assistance in all aspects.

Vertin: ... So, you have seen what the "Storm" was like?

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: The outside world ... is very different from what I thought.

Sonetto: As the Timekeeper, you've always carried such a secret for us. Thank you.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: Thank you for bringing the message, Sonetto.

Vertin: So, what's the first mission for our team?

Sonetto: Please take a look.

Sonetto: According to the latest historical intelligence, there will be a massacre against arcanists in Chicago on February 14.

Sonetto: We need to rescue the victims before human gangsters arrive at the underground parking.

Vertin: Rescue the arcanists?

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: It doesn't conflict with the Foundation's purpose, right? Preventing confrontations between two races is also a way to defend the peace of mankind.

Sonetto: Although this is different from all the missions before.

Sonetto: The authorities would probably want us to recruit new arcanists for the Foundation as much as possible.

Vertin: I see.

Vertin: The forces of the Manus expand dramatically year by year. To stop the trend, we do need additional manpower.

Vertin: But ... Sonetto, did you have oranges just now? There is a scent of orange on the capsule.

Sonetto: How come? I did not. And ... I will definitely wash my hands after eating.

Vertin: Maybe that's my mistake. If there is no question, we are ready to go ...

Regulus: Whoa! You guys, come here and help!

Sonetto: It is ... Regulus's voice? Why is her voice coming from above ...

Sonetto: Whoa!

Regulus: Our ... our suitcase is about to be moved by the critters!

APPLe: Ms. Vertin! Sonetto!

APPLe: Seems like our suitcase has disturbed some imps! Captain went out to check but got trapped!

Choices

1. Hurry up and help!

APPLe: Captain, hang in there!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Sharpodonty and Black Wine · 1/2

1ST-05

Sharpodonties and Black Wine

APPLe: Even the tree hole is not safe enough ...

Vertin: ... We should go. I will carry it with me along the way.

Vertin: But Regulus ...

Regulus: Hm? What's that worried look?

Regulus: Come on, Sonetto gave me a floppy disk. I'll reach the quarter 100% safe!

Choices

1. Don't take too long.

2. Run if you can't win.

Branch 1

Regulus: I know. It's not very often I've seen you like that.

Branch 2

Regulus: Uggh ...

Regulus: I-I'm not there to fight!

Shared continuation

Regulus: I gotta split then! This is a free trip. I'll definitely enjoy myself. Ha-ha! ♪

Sonetto: Let's get ready to move.

Sonetto: The mission is in the underground parking at No. 2122 Lincoln Park Street, two blocks away from us. We still have plenty of time ...

Sonetto: Can ... could we go there by bus?

Choices

1. Sure. Enjoy the scenery.

APPLe: Oh ... it's so cold here. This APPLe is getting frosty.

Sonetto: Really? I seem to feel nothing. It's actually kind of warm, compared to our routine training at low temperatures.

Sonetto: According to the intelligence, now it's still one hour before the incident. Hmm ...

Sonetto: So this is the distance from the entrance to the wall, and here should also be marked ...

APPLe: What you're depicting in the air ... Is that the reconstruction of the victims' position?

Sonetto: Yes, I reconstructed to actual scale. In this way I can calculate the position that can provide cover without hindering us from joining the battle in time.

Sonetto: For anything that may cost others' lives, I want to be as cautious as possible. What if ...

Sonetto: Huh. No, never mind. I am not worried about my own life. I am just ...

Vertin: It's fine.

Vertin: They won't know.

APPLe: Shh ...! Someone's here. Two human drunks!

Sonetto: Don't let them wander around. It's too dangerous here! The gang fight will definitely hurt them.

Choices

1. Stun them first.

Wall Street Journal

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

Sharpodonty and Black Wine · 2/2

1ST-05

Vertin: How's it going?

Sonetto: Skin damage: less than or equal to five millimeters. No visceral damage or psychube fluctuation found for the moment. Conclusion: the injuries meet the requirements of Emergency Defense Code of St. Pavlov Foundation.

Vertin: It will probably take some time for them to wake up. Hide them under the car first.

Vertin: We don't have much time. Let's hurry to the hidden position. … Mr. APPLe, why are you a little upset?

APPLe: … This APPLe found a pack of sharpodonties in their pocket, and a child's finger …

APPLe: … Which are the currencies that only used by arcanists.

Sonetto: …

Sonetto: Maybe … that's just …

APPLe: It's 1929, a year full of racial discrimination.

Sonetto: …

Sonetto: … This is also the reason why we need to stop the next tragedy. For the peace of all mankind.

Sonetto: Outside the silent underground parking, a piercing sound of brakes cut through.

Vertin: There're still 30 minutes. Who's coming early …

Vertin: Pap, pap, pap.

Sonetto: Gunshots?! Wha …? But the arcanists haven't got here …

Vertin: … Damn it. Let's go!

TO BE CONTINUED…

The Rosa Killer · 1/2

1ST-06

The Rosa Killer

???: James Clark.

James Clark: ...!

???: Peter Gusenberg.

Peter Gusenberg: Uggh ...

Sonetto: ...!

???: Frank Gusenberg.

Sonetto: Stop it!

Sonetto: Why are you killing them?!

???: Hm ...?

???: Because they want to kill the arcanists?

???: Aren't you also here for this? Ms. Governors ... who know history very well.

???: So, next on the list is ... Adam Heyer.

Adam Heyer: Ah ... why can't I shoot her ... why ...!

Sonetto: Timekeeper!

Choices

1. Rescue Adam Heyer.

APPLe: Be careful with her gun. Seems it is not our body that she is aiming at.

Intermission

小径

What are you doing? Why did you pick up that cold, opaque, opalescent glass wine bottle from the ground—at this most critical moment?

The scream outside the parking lot, the friction between the brake pads and the wheel drums, or the story unfolding like Giallo films. Obviously, none of them are as impressive as this bottle.

I can tell that you got good taste. You know it's not easy to get this stuff these days.

But, why are you staring at the bottom and licking your lips? Tell me, you are not going to take a sip, are you?

This is not a wise choice. You can't see the color of the liquid inside the glass. Maybe it's not the ice wine, or beer, or any homemade alcohol.

It's probably—very likely—just a critter's snot. Even so, do you still wanna give it a try?

Choices

1. Come off it. I'll take a shot.

2. I really shouldn't click this bottle.

Branch 1

Every Carbuncle you've ever met will appreciate your courage.

Now, some cold liquid runs through your throat. It trickles slowly, most likely because it's thick. But the taste is much smoother than you think.

Then, a faint scent of absinthe greeted your nostril, and maltose, and lemon thyme, and coconut sugar. It's as delicious as a present from the arcanist from New Zealand.

And at the same time, your heart swells, and you feel a scorching energy fill your windpipe.

Your vision begins to blur. You kinda see the rough letter on the bottom: The Walden Potion Bar.

Choices

1. What the F**k is this?

It's anything but alcohol! "Alcohol" is a taboo. But it will empower you to face the next damn reality.

Choices

1. Who are you?

Me? Ha, I am no one.

But I can also be anyone—a drunken, slovenly old man, a cleaner in a run-down hotel, a fund manager greedy for more, or a cute spinning crystal skull.

Now I'm a drunkard with good taste, just like you.

And the day when we formally meet each other is coming soon.

Now, lift your big ass and continue your wonderful journey. I will appear at any time, any moment, no matter you expect or not.

Branch 2

Right. It only took one moment for you to decide to click, while you had to stand so much nonsense for no reason.

My apologies if the story didn't unfold as you expected. But luckily, you still have your sanity that you are always proud of.

Come here. Let's put down the bottle. Before Sonetto and that floating APPLe notice your unusual behavior, you still have a chance to restore your image.

After me, say "Hi" to them. Pretend you've never been tempted by the bottle.

Choices

1. "Hi."

2. Are you sure they can hear it?

Branch 2.1

Oh. Hi! How are you doing?

Hahahahaha. Excellent. Now we all know how effective the training of the Foundation is. Good news: everyone likes good kids.

It's so nice talking to you. You're better than your ... Oops, I should stop here.

Choices

1. Who the hell are you?

Me? Ha, I am no one.

But I can also be anyone—a drunken, slovenly old man, a cleaner in a run-down hotel, a fund manager greedy for more, or a cute spinning crystal skull.

Now I am a nice and friendly adventurer, just like you.

Don't worry. The day when we formally meet each other is coming soon.

Now, lift your big ass and continue your wonderful journey. I will appear at any time, any moment, no matter you expect or not.

Branch 2.2

...

I really wanna find out what you're composed of! I'll chew and swallow all the gene analysis down to my stomach, so I can figure out ... how did you keep your sanity!

No arcanist is ever as rational and restrained as you. They should, they should ... If there is really one in the world, that should be ...

And I know so much about you. Too much about you! Even I cannot deny what you are. I can't!

Choices

1. Who the hell are you?

Me? Ha, I am no one.

But I can also be anyone—a drunken, slovenly old man, a cleaner in a run-down hotel, a fund manager greedy for more, or a cute spinning crystal skull.

But now I'm only a rubber asshole whose mischief just failed. A desperate loser. My wrath can't even burn a weed in the Pacific Ocean.

I'm looking forward to the day we formally meet each other. Only then ...

Now, lift your big ass and continue your wonderful journey. I will appear at any time, any moment, no matter you expect or not!

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Intermission

The Rosa Killer · 2/2

1ST-06

???: Umm huh. The last human ... You saved him?

Adam Heyer: *ragged breathing*

Sonetto: I got you. Please stand behind us. I will escort you to somewhere safe ...

Adam Heyer: ... You guys are also arcanists?

Adam Heyer: Ha ha ... Hahahaha ...! D******e!

APPLe: Pap.

Sonetto: Huh!

Sonetto: ... Kill ... he killed himself ...?!

APPLe: Carotid artery ruptures. We lost him.

???: What a pity. Is it because the arcanist's blood is so dirty ... that he would rather die than go with you?

???: But life is precious. I ... do not want anyone to waste it ...

Schneider: Pap.

Schneider: Pap.

Vertin: Enough.

Vertin: Those unconscious arcanists behind you ... are the original victims, right?

Vertin: You are bringing them back to Manus Vindictae?

???: ...

???: You ... are much more interesting than the stubborn old woman next to you.

???: You are also gorgeous ... Oh, your hair color is quite similar to the feather I like ... Ah ha, I'm getting excited.

Vertin: Answer my question.

???: Hmm ... hmm, that's harsh.

???: We are just on to the same people. Before the "Storm," everyone wants more useful guys.

???: In that way, your destiny and mine ... are they now tightly connected?

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: None of the seven are alive ... How much do you hate humans that you could kill them like that?

???: ... Hate humans?

???: Then tell me ... in this massacre in history, who should be killed, human or arcanist?

Choices

1. No one should be killed.

Vertin: ... Difference in talent is never, and never will be the reason to deprive people of life.

???: Hum, bingo, Ms. Governor. Arcanist, or mortal ... I ... umm ... don't really think it matters.

???: As long as we survive, it's all good.

APPLe: What's in the shadow ...? She's holding a ritual? Stop her! She is going to take those arcanists away!

Vertin: ...!

???: Umm. Although I like you very much, I still have to finish my task ...

???: This is the reward for killing Adam for me. Don't forget me.

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: That's it? She's gone? What are these ...

APPLe: Stock gift agreement?

Sonetto: She even left us stolen goods?

Sonetto: Don't worry. I will deal with them right now.

Vertin: Wait.

Vertin: There's an address on the seal—Polypotion Bar, The Walden.

Vertin: Sonetto, update the result to the headquarters.

Sonetto: Roger that. And we ...

Vertin: Let's move on to the next destination.

Vertin: The Walden ... It may have the answer to all the questions.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Scorched Woods

1ST-07

Scorched Woods

???_1: It would be our honor to have the young lady's presence at The Walden.

???_1: Thanks to your kindness last time, we were able to invent the new potion before the National Prohibition Act was enacted. Of course, I will deliver what you had purposed on time.

???_1: Yes, everything is fine ... No, you don't have to worry too much about Congress.

???_1: You need to trust them.

???_1: Humans, they talk the talk and don't walk the walk, but they're more likely to vote for the side that seems more ethical.

???_1: Please be rest assured. We will make the young lady's day a pleasant one.

???_1: Hmm ... it's good weather.

???_1: And ideal for an impressive "Storm."

Manor hall

???: According to Louise Strong's column on New Yorker on February 5, Duke Ellington's jazz orchestra will perform at The Walden tonight!

???_1: It will be the best ever! Wild! Rhythmic! Fancy! Just what a jazz band should be ...

Mr. Karson: There you go, Ms. Sotheby. There's no need to deliberately read that aloud.

Mr. Karson: Master in England has given you the permission to go out. Also, I've spoken to the owner of The Walden on the phone ...

Sotheby: Hooray!

Mr. Karson: Hooray? That's not what a young lady should say.

Sotheby: Mr. Karson, Sotheby has grown up.

Sotheby: And I am not going out to play this time. I also have the great mission of saving people.

Mr. Karson: Fine, fine. Just don't go hawking your new nutrient potions. Ms. Moissan would be worried if she saw you come back disappointed.

Sotheby: ... Then I'm leaving!

Mr. Karson: Wrong way, my lady. The car is at the front door.

Sotheby: Huh! I-I don't need a bodyguard! You promised I could go out alone this time!

Mr. Karson: Mind your manners, my lady. There isn't a bodyguard there for you this time.

Mr. Karson: The wood near the bar is quite dangerous. We must pick you up in person for peace of mind.

Mr. Karson: In brief, after entering the bar, staff will lead you to your seat.

Mr. Karson: Remember, watching only. No alcoholic or incitant potion drinks. Do not talk to strangers. Black bottom is not allowed ...

Mr. Karson: Hmm? My lady?

Sotheby: I! Got! It!

Mr. Karson: *sighs*

Borderlands

Mr. Karson: Creaking ... Creaking ...

Sonetto: The woods ... so gloomy.

Sonetto: All the plants are dead. There is no evidence of life at all. Even the bark on the branches are charred.

Sonetto: Looks like it has been through a huge fire.

Sonetto: Well, if it were not the path we must take, I really don't want to enter this woods ...

Vertin: Speaking of which, Sonetto, have you ever heard of a ghost story about "fire"?

Sonetto: ...?!

Sonetto: No. Never.

Vertin: Oh. So it is said that in the early 20th century, there was a devastating forest fire in Washington.

Vertin: Those who died unfortunately did not want to leave, and they turned into dark ghosts in the woods.

Sonetto: Um ...

Vertin: They follow the travelers without making any sounds, and in order to see everyone's face clearly, they will ...

Sonetto: Ah! I can't hear you clearly ... It's too noisy walking on these dried leaves. All I heard is the whizzing sound behind me.

APPLe: True, this APPLe heard some loud noise, too.

Sonetto: ... Umm? Mr. APPLe, why are you in front of me? Then ...

???: ...!

Sonetto: Ahh! Gho-ghost ...

Vertin: Lots of unknown creatures! Sonetto, stay behind me!

Choices

1. Everyone, get ready to fight!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Afflatus Relations

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Trail ② News

小径

On Bankrupt Companies and Newly Registered Companies: February

> Public Notice
> (1929) IL 17-14000 BD59-3
>
> Great Lakes Media Company, located in Roosevelt Road, the parent company of the Moon Post of Arcanum, does not possess any distributable assets. The debtors Theodore Jackson (Human), Emilio Robert Henger (Human), and manager Steven Sheridan (Human) have applied for the termination of the bankruptcy proceedings following negotiations.
> The Moon Post of Arcanum specializes in reporting news of the arcanist world with a

circulation of over 500,000 copies. Renowned articles include Conspiracy: Human Organ Trade and the Witch's Curse. Its parent company Great Lakes Media Company was forced to stop its publication in September 1928 due to anonymous reports to relevant authorities and the emergence of radio stations.
Pursuant to the provisions of The Nelson Act, this Court has reached the verdict of terminating the bankruptcy proceedings of the Great Lakes Media Company in February 14, 1929.
Declared on

February 24, 1929

Public Notice
·List of Newly Registered Companies·

Name: Feldwood Communications Company
Legal Representative: David Clauberg (Human)
Scope of business: Media publishing - Arcanum Global Weekly
Date of establishment: February 3, 1929

Name: Karl Entertainment Publishing Company
Legal representative: Vince Dayne (Human)
Scope of business: Media publishing - American Wizard Entertainments
Date of establishment: February 3, 1929

Name: Coast United Publishing Company
Legal representative: Hugh Midax (Human)
Scope of business: Media publishing - Evening News
Date of establishment: February 5, 1929

.....
Declared on

February 14, 1929

Trail ③ An Unknown Traveller I

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Druvis III · 1/2

1ST-08

Druvis Ⅲ

Critters: *appear*

Critters: Sss!

Vertin: No, too many of them. We can only take one round at most, not for long.

APPLe: Critters keep coming from the roots. Are they living here?

Critters: ...!

Vertin: Coming again. Careful!

Trail ① Incantation Upgrade
小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Incredible Unicorn
小径

Looking Backwards

Druvis III · 2/2
1ST-08

APPLe: *coughing*

Sonetto: Timekeeper, did you see my mark on the map?

Vertin: Yes.

Sonetto: According to my calculation, that's the closest position to the edge of the woods.

Sonetto: In one minute, I'll cover you to move in the opposite direction! Remember, there's a slope two miles away that can slow down the critters.

APPLe: Ms. Sonetto, aren't you coming with us?

Sonetto: Suppressed by such an overwhelming number, we can't get out!

Sonetto: Don't worry. The action strategy would be more flexible if there's only me.

Sonetto: As long as the enemies are not ghosts ... no, even if they are ghosts, I will survive.

Choices

1. I trust you.

2. Where do we meet then?

Branch 1

Sonetto: Please trust me. Just like ... how we used to be.

Branch 2

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: I will always find you. Please retreat quickly.

Shared continuation

Vertin: Let's go, Mr. APPLe.

Sonetto: May the peace be with us.

Critters: ...!

Critters: ...!

APPLe: They are all coming for us!

Vertin: ... It's a good thing.

Vertin: Maybe we covered Sonetto.

Vertin: As long as one of us can leave the woods, there's hope for the rest.

Critters: ...!!

Vertin: Too late to climb up the slope. Get ready to fight!

Vertin: Mr. APPLe, how much longer can you hold on?

APPLe: Though it may not sound like what an apple should say ... this APPLe will fight with you to the last moment!

Critters: ...!

APPLe: Vertin, look out!

???: Hmm?

???: No offense.

???: Would you please pass me my heel?

???: It seems to have fallen into your arms.

Choices

1. ... Who are you?

2. ... Why are you in such a high place?

Branch 1

Druvis III: I am Druvis III, the owner of the woods.

Branch 2

???: This is my promised land.

Druvis III: I am Druvis III. It's my pleasure to meet you.

Shared continuation

Vertin: ... The heels ... here you are.

Druvis III: Thank you. Then I will come down and clean up the mess.

Druvis III: It's fine to land barefoot. However ...

Druvis III: I don't like touching them directly ...

Druvis III: ... These invaders.

Critters: ...!

APPLe: She beats hundreds of them with one single move?! Is it the power of her wand ...?

APPLe: No, the arcane circle she cast is pretty archaic. She must have a European arcanum background.

Druvis III: It has been a long time since I saw the arcanist visitors.

Druvis III: Thank you for helping me expel the critters. Then, as for the ones left ...

Druvis III: Just as the woods prophesy in whisper—invaders, you shall offer your sacrifice for the peace.

Vertin: Please allow us to assist you!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Security Carnival

1ST-09

Security Carnival

APPLe: Finally, we are safe now.

Vertin: Thank you very much for your help, Ms. Druvis.

Druvis Ⅲ: You ran a long way into the woods. Are you looking for the girl with orange hair?

Vertin: Yes.

Druvis Ⅲ: I "see" her get rid of the critters, and take a dark green Bentley to the northwest.

Druvis Ⅲ: The woods know where the visitors go, leading them astray, or to the light.

Druvis Ⅲ: And your friend, she has good fortune.

Vertin: The exit on the northwest ... It's quite close to The Walden on the map.

Druvis Ⅲ: The Walden?

Druvis Ⅲ: Now I see. You are also here for the Storm Gathering tonight.

Vertin: What is the Storm Gathering?

Druvis Ⅲ: It is a gathering of elite arcanists from all states. Besides, celebrities and frequenters familiar with the barkeeper are also invited.

Druvis Ⅲ: I think ... there will be the regular duel performances, a banquet that is too noisy, and the announcement of "good news."

APPLe: Do you know what exactly the "good news" is, Ms. Druvis?

Druvis Ⅲ: My apologies. I am not interested in that.

Druvis Ⅲ: Hmm ... but if you want to know the "good news," you might as well take my invitation and take a look.

Druvis Ⅲ: This is a secret gathering in a speakeasy. It's by invitation only ... and a stock coupon of at least 50,000 dollars is needed.

Vertin: Stock? Why does it always have something to do with financial securities ...

APPLe: We had a subscription agreement before, but ... it was burned by our friend ...

Druvis Ⅲ: ... That's all right. But you can actually get here with nothing.

Druvis Ⅲ: "Stock prices have reached what looks like a permanently high plateau." Have you heard about this?

Druvis Ⅲ: Nowadays, cash is not used for transactions. The application of arcanum has made stock exchange surprisingly convenient.

Druvis Ⅲ: The urban agglomerations expand rapidly in the new era, and even the critters have lost their home. Only loans and the infinitely soaring stock market could satisfy such a huge desire.

Vertin: ...

APPLe: It is similar to the history this APPLe knows, but sounds a little different ...

Druvis Ⅲ: ... This is the Gift Agreement for the 50,000 US dollars coupon. If you're still going to the gathering, take it with you.

Vertin: You are not going?

Druvis Ⅲ: Thank you for asking, but I ... do not want to leave the woods for now.

Choices

1. Sign the real name.

Stockbroker: Hello, I am your personal stockbroker. Your grantee application has been received ... Application approved ... Account updated.

Stockbroker: Thank you for your support to blue-chip stock.

Stockbroker: The real estate market is on fire today. Now we have customized recommendations for you ...

APPLe: We're good, thank you.

Druvis Ⅲ: The exit of the woods is at the end of the road, next to the three cypresses. I will leave you here then. May the woods bless you with fortune.

Druvis Ⅲ: And ...

Druvis Ⅲ: ... If you see the barkeeper, please send him my best regards.

???: Lord Forget Me Not, you had a good day.

Walden

Forget Me Not: The men I need, have you brought them back?

???: M-hmm ... Seven arcanists, not even missing a single cutie finger.

???: They are all very interested in the doctrine of the Manus. Soon, they will become your devout desperados.

???: I did my job so perfectly. What rewards will there be for me? Heh heh.

Forget Me Not: I heard that you didn't take care of the redundancies.

???: Hmm, I don't really remember ... in the mission, there are instructions to kill civilians.

???: Or say ... for you, the arcanists who are not pure-blooded are just worthless? Heh Heh.

???: Even if we are from a southern mafia, we do care about brotherhood. We can't be as ruthless as the "Storm."

Forget Me Not: For the special ones, of course we Manus will make exceptions. Just like now, we are still searching for your missing sister, Schneider.

Schneider: Thank you for being considerate.

Schneider: She strolls lazily towards the door.

Forget Me Not: Your stepsister Marian must be extremely touched if she knows how much you value her.

Forget Me Not: You were adopted by the Grecos after all. It's not like you are related to those ... humans by blood.

Schneider: No matter what, we are "families" and have lived together for more than ten years.

Schneider: Thank you for caring so much about Marian.

Schneider: Although I think I've never mentioned ... which sister is missing.

Schneider: Mamma.

Schneider: Mamma, pack up. Let's leave tonight.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Hello, Ms. Sonetto

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Trail ② Tactic to Disarm

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

The Origin Butterfly

1ST-10

The Origin Butterfly

Vertin: Hello. Please get me Madam Z of St. Pavlov Foundation Committee.

Z: Hmm. It's you. What's wrong?

Vertin: I require access to the historical intelligence on the U.S. financial market in 1929, specifically the date of the Wall Street stock market crash, and how much arcanum was involved in the methods of stock exchange.

Z: Anything else?

Vertin: ... Also, I request sending backup to reinforce the Storm Gathering tonight. Casual wear required.

Z: The date of the 1929 Crash confirmed by primary sources is Thursday, October 24. And the decline happened again, on the 28th and 29th.

Z: Intelligence Division indicates that no arcane forces were involved.

Vertin: Hmm ...

Vertin: The Manus is changing history, Madam Z.

Z: I'll send you a special team and give you the highest command.

Z: Do not make any moves until you figure out the reason why they want to change the history.

Vertin: Copy that.

St.Pavlov Foundation

Z: Sounds like your friend just got into some troubles, Regulus.

Regulus: ... *tuts*

Regulus: I'd say, sign these documents and that's all for me, right? And then to the office of Scientific Computing Center?

???: That's right. Let me show you the way, Regulus.

Z: En. This is X, our mechanical scientist. He will introduce you to some of our research devices ...

Z: Although you are known for your rock and roll, I've heard that you're also interested in human technology.

Regulus: Oh I got it. I don't need to introduce myself then. Just call me Captain R!

X: Heh heh. That's not what our names come from.

X: Follow me, friend from afar. I have a lot of interesting new things to show you.

X: The office is the only branch of the Scientific Computing Center affiliated with the Foundation. So, only the paper materials can be shared.

X: Hmm ...

Regulus: Hey! Why do you stop! I almost hit you.

X: The introduction of the Scientific Computing Center is over, and your sightseeing tour ends here.

X: Would you like to know something more interesting?

X: For example ... the truth of the "Storm"?

Regulus: ... What do you know?

X: Not me. It's we. We're from a secret institution inside the Scientific Computing Center—Institutum Lorentz.

X: We are the ones who invited you to visit the Scientific Computing Center. Although you didn't bring the "little thing" with you, I believe it's still necessary for us to know each other.

Regulus: Humph. So, it seems everyone of the Foundation is an intelligence expert.

X: We are not part of the Foundation, not even part of the Scientific Computing Center.

X: Unlike the Manus rioters who attacked you for your "little thing" ...

X: We are only interested in the arcanists who are curious and inquisitive. Everything else has nothing to do with us. To better understand the "Storm," Lorentz needs more talented collaborators.

Regulus: Hmm ...

Regulus: So, does the door in front of us lead to your secret base?

X: For now, yes.

Regulus: ...

Regulus: I can't see anything inside.

Regulus: ...

Regulus: Vertin and Sonetto, what are they doing now ...

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① To Another Castle

小径

Mrs. Greco puts down the phone. She is now as calm as any Italian mother you've ever met. You know, they're usually making a yummy pie before they pull out their guns.

There are enough people in black outside, enough to prevent any eavesdropping or violent conflict.

Mrs. Greco glanced blandly over the one, two, three, four ... nine, ten, eleven children in front of her. This is a big family, and it has grown bigger and bigger over the past few years because of Schneider.

Choices

1. Who are they?

2. Who is Mrs. Greco?

Branch 1

They're Schneider's sisters. It's hard for the Grecos to tell them apart. But Schneider is different.

But Schneider is different. She was born in an earthquake, all covered in blood, and didn't let out her first cry until two hours later. It wasn't until she was one year old that her father noticed that she had never been baptized.

Branch 2

She's Schneider's biological mother. You see her furrowed face, like a hard stone wall, while inside the wall is all about a pious farmer's life.

The Grecos are not good at dealing with gang affairs. They can't even figure out when their daughter has grown—grown into the backbone of the whole family.

When Schneider took out 500 dollars from her pocket and put them on the table, they were completely shocked, and that's just the beginning.

Schneider ... Schneider, the youngest daughter they seldom cared about. It's impossible to keep every child well-fed. Schneider could not even get a piece of bread in the Eucharist.

But a good daughter would not let anyone worry about her. She sat on the bench outside the church and hummed. She found a way out for herself. She walked to the underground market, fascinated by what she saw ...

She announced her "new identity" one day.

Choices

1. What "new identity"?

2. What bread?

Branch 2.1

The identity you know now.

In the process, she lost something old but gained something new, no matter if she wished for it or not.

Branch 2.2

The bread provided in some sacred religious ceremonies. According to different teachings, it's sometimes flatbread, sometimes fermented bread, or sometimes any kind of bread.

"Now," Mrs. Greco said, "we live, or we die. If Schneider comes back safely tonight ... we will leave when the moon rises."

"The doors are closing in front of us, one after another. But the benevolent Maria will give us the ultimate shelter. My children, remember today forever."

Her words speak for her status. But Mrs. Greco's eyes never moved away from that small Madonna on the table. The hem of her clothes were soaked in tears.

4 p.m. A family is determined to start a new journey.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

From One Castle To Another

Trail ② Critter's Sheet

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Charge Baby, Charge! · 1/2

1ST-11

Charge Baby, Charge!

Sonetto: ...

Sotheby: Dear Freddy, could you make the "Auto Island" move faster? Our Ms. Sonetto has something really urgent!

Freddy The Driver: Miss, we cannot speed up anymore. Mr. Karson will be mad if we race in the woods.

Sotheby: Oh ... then how long will it take to The Walden?

Freddy The Driver: Probably ... half an hour.

Sotheby: Oh my ... it's too long! We promised Ms. Sonetto to find her friends, right?

Sotheby: We keep going slowly, we will miss Ms. Vertin!

Sotheby: Fine. Freddy. Quick. Drink it!

Sotheby: It's the "Bravery Charging Hopping Potion" I made this morning! Just drink it!

Sonetto: Er, what are you ... Wait a minute!

Freddy The Driver: *swallowing*

Freddy The Driver: Mi-Miss ... you are really going ... to sell ... your potion ...

Sotheby: See? Now you've got a lot more strength, right?

Sotheby: I added the most effective tears of the pure-blooded Koresck and the strongest bile acid of blue lobster.

Sotheby: Definitely makes you forget the fears, and be courageous, and excited for two whole days without food and drink!

Sonetto: Ms. Sotheby, did you feed him a whole bottle of that? It's too dangerous!

Freddy The Driver: Whoaaaaaa!!

Sonetto: Too bad ... he doesn't look right ... Hold the handrail!

Freddy The Driver: Whoa, whoa, whoahhh, I've never feel so good in my whole life! Charge baby, charge, charge to high Heaven!

Freddy The Driver: The wheels on the bus go round and round, round and round, round and round ...♪

Sonetto&Sotheby: Woaaah!!

Sonetto: No way ... too fast! The speed ... i-i-it's illegal in the city. Ahhhhhh!

Sotheby: Hey, Freddy! We're at the bar already! Don't ... step on it!

Sotheby: St-stop ... already ... help ...!

Sonetto&Sotheby: Hitting the wall!!

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: Oh ... it hurts.

Sonetto: Ms. Sotheby, Ms. Sotheby, are you alright?

Sotheby: Um ...

Sotheby: Where are we? I know we crashed into the back wall of The Walden ...

Sonetto: Yes. But it looks like ...

Sonetto: ... like an underground labyrinth.

Sotheby: Whoa ...! Di-did we really crash into the back wall of the bar?! The "Auto Island" ... it's stuck in the wall?

Sotheby: Freddy! Oh ... fortunately you just passed out.

Sotheby: Oh ... This is too bad. This is real bad ... If Mr. Karson knows I broke the barkeeper's wall ... oh ...

Sonetto: The car stuck in the wall ... We have to find another way out.

Sotheby: Le-let's get out of here quickly, before Mr. Karson knows it!

???: *appear*

Sonetto: Gosh! The crash just now wakened the critters in the underground ...

Sotheby: Hm? Let me see what it looks like!

Sotheby: Ah! It's the Carbuncle that's parasitic on the dust! They all act in groups. Generally speaking, if you see one Carbuncle, it means ...

Sotheby: There's a large group of Carbuncles around here ...

???: ...!

Sonetto: We have to beat them before we leave.

Sotheby: Ok. Let's do it! M-my alchemy will definitely come in handy!

Matilda's School Report

小径

SF School of Primary Defense of Mankind

Chapter 1 Transfer Student of SF School of Primary Defense of Mankind
Chapter 2 The Tall and Mature Ms. Bouanich
Chapter 3 Ms. Bouanich and Assistant Ms. Sonetto
Chapter 4 Secrets of the Campus Citadel
Chapter 5 Ms. Bouanich and Her Assistant Sonetto's Happy Vacation
...
Chapter 17 Farewell after Graduation
Chapter 18 Monitor Assistant?!
Chapter 19 Special Field Task

Charge Baby, Charge! · 2/2

1ST-11

Sonetto: Freddy ... leave him to me. I will carry him.

Sonetto: Ms. Sotheby, you seem to know The Walden better. Please lead the way.

Sotheby: Sure! No problem! Though it looks different from the bar I imagined, I will definitely find the right way out!

???: Please ... help me ...

???: Schneider ... it hurts so much ...

Sonetto: Who's there?

Sotheby: Hm? Who are you talking to?

Sonetto: I just heard ... Is it my mistake?

Sonetto: No. It's not.

Sonetto: The liquid flowing out of the wall ... It's a mixture of human blood and vomitus.

Sonetto: This is ... Truth Serum?

Sotheby: Ms. Sonetto? Why are you talking to yourself against the wall? If you want to get out soon, follow me!

Sonetto: I will be there right away.

Sotheby: Okay. I already know where to go! Follow Sotheby. Let's go left!

Sonetto: ... It shouldn't be a mistake. There is a human imprisoned by arcanum in this speakeasy. I have to report it to the Timekeeper as soon as possible.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Appetizers · 1/2

1ST-12

Appetizers

I'm surrounded by distances like a flag,

sense the winds that are coming, I stand and must flutter,

yet things below are not stirred:

Stocks celebrate, and the prices emulate

on a Thursday afternoon, when the sun shines as before.

Gold forms the line, reaching a lasting high plateau.

I know the storms and am excited like the sea.

And I spread out and fall into myself

and throw myself, all alone into the great storm.

Vertin: Thanks for coming to assist.

Special Action Team Captain: To make you ask Madam Z for help, it must be tough here.

Vertin: I just don't feel good about this. Hopefully it's my misjudgment. Is everyone in position?

Special Action Team Captain: Yes. Eight of the team got the invitation to the gathering. They have entered separately. Others are standing by at every entrance of the speakeasy.

Special Action Team Captain: These are the intels we got about The Walden. They're going to hold a live duel show tonight.

Special Action Team Captain: Fighters can win stock in amount of 1 million dollars, and the betting odds can be from 5-to-1 to 10-to-1.

Vertin: ... They are crazy.

Special Action Team Captain: Timekeeper, please take this with you.

Special Action Team Captain: It's the latest product from the Scientific Computing Center, "Heaven Apostle 34:7." They've added the cell sap of Bombard Ball to it. Unfold its wing and it will blast in 15 seconds.

Special Action Team Captain: The blast is undirectional. Please watch your position when you use it.

Vertin: Got it. Let's head down to The Walden now. You follow APPLe. Remember, to stay low profile.

Forget Me Not: Welcome, welcome everyone ...

Walden

Forget Me Not: All the new immigrants, arcanists, moralities and immoralities, Anti-Saloon League and democratic progressives, free thinkers and church-goers ...

Forget Me Not: Welcome to your eternal home, The Walden.

Forget Me Not: How was it? You seem to be enjoying the last show, the Hooch Dance girl with the Boa constrictor.

Forget Me Not: Well, in that case, next round's Python Sweet is all on me. I assure you every Chicagoan loves the YY Bourbon. You won't forget its charm.

Forget Me Not: Oh, oh, I guess your eyes are fixed on the charts. Don't worry, my friends. Let's focus on the next duel instead.

Forget Me Not: Trust me, and you'll get the return beyond your craziest imagination.

APPLe: Oh, so crowded! This APPLe's favorite bow tie almost gets lost!

APPLe: Why is this speakeasy so busy? It doesn't look like an illegal place at all.

Special Action Team Captain: This is the only speakeasy in the states that has never been given a shakedown. It's said that Forget Me Not, owner of the speakeasy, can make a potion drink which is not alcoholic until people drink it.

Special Action Team Captain: From purchasing raw materials, getting a medical store license, distilling, transporting and selling, and ensuring the security together with gangs, we got nothing on them.

Special Action Team Captain: It welcomes all the marginals, and doles out patronage positions. Through this, The Walden has already cemented itself as the one above all other speakeasies in Chicago.

Vertin: Did you find out the relationship between Manus Vindictae and him?

Special Action Team Captain: No. His document was edited purposely, but we can be sure that he is from this era.

Special Action Team Captain: However, we found that the time he made contact with the politicians was close to the beginning of the unusual boom of the domestic financial market.

Special Action Team Captain: Since then, you can't talk about arcane stock trading without mentioning The Walden.

Forget Me Not: Alright, my friends!

Forget Me Not: Shh.

Forget Me Not: We are about to have a taste of tonight's appetizer.

Forget Me Not: Let's welcome our fighter of the year! The defender of the undefeated honor of knocking out ten consecutive arcanists and human challengers!

Vertin: It's her?!

All Guests: *cheering*

Forget Me Not: Then, which guest will have the honor to be the challenger of the duel?

Guest I: A million dollar coupon! You get beat the crap out, and lie on bed for two months. Worth it!

Vip Guest: Haha, I prefer betting. Maybe I can get a Hamptons' villa!

Forget Me Not: The fate of this challenger, we let the spotlight decide.

Forget Me Not: The spotlight chose you, lady with a top hat.

Vertin: S**t!

All Guests: What a lucky guy!

All Guests: Come on! Get on the stage!

Forget Me Not: I give you, Schneider, the defending champion of last year, and the Timekeeper from St. Pavlov Foundation, Ms. Vertin.

Special Action Team Captain: S**t! They got our intels too?

Vertin: ... I'm going. Don't worry.

Forget Me Not: And now, let the duel begin.

Schneider: Heh heh, long time no see, Ms. Governor.

Schneider: It seems my lord would like to see me kill you myself. He has even created such a chance on purpose.

Schneider: Pap.

Schneider: Oops, I missed it.

Schneider: Come on. Why do you have to waste your life? Are you here to enforce justice of the Foundation?

Schneider: Pap.

Schneider: The Foundation obviously has no justice. You don't even dare make the "Storm" public.

Schneider: Turn down my "families" with ridiculous lies. Is that your so-called justice?

Schneider: Pap, pap, pap.

Schneider: The fragrance of orange blossom on her suddenly opens out in the air.

Vertin: You've been there? The scent of orange on Sonetto's mission capsule ... That's why you can hijack the hostages outside the parking?

Schneider: Heh heh ... There is no shelter there for me. Then all I can do is to complete the tasks for my lord.

Schneider: Oops, I just lost my focus. I will become serious now!

Trail ① The Strange Thing in the Labyrinth
小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Trail ② Chat in front of the Bar
小径

A Letter with Black Mucus

"Chaos begins where the butterfly flutters its wings."

—— Institutum Lorentz ——

Founded after the "Storm," Institutum Lorentz is a mysterious organization hidden within but independent of the Laplace Scientific Computing Center. Its primary area of research is the chaos energy of Arcanum. Its members distrust the tech of human civilization and would rather discard them. They're active in various sites of arcane phenomena, secretly searching for the "Original Butterfly."
While all of its members' whereabouts remain unknown, Lorentz still has branches all over the world. Our vanguard squad has fought their investigators several times, yet we still haven't found a way into any of their branches.

Appetizers · 2/2
1ST-12

Guest: Whoooah! I'm gonna raise! Just on that Ver-Ver-Ver-whatever!

Vip Guest: Come on! The champion! I bet all my money on you!

Thomas: Ah, the Dow rockets to 381.17?! Then I-I add 5,000 more!

Schneider: Aha. Nice! Nice! Ms. Governor, you're much better than I thought.

Schneider: Not like the little punks in the Foundation.

Vertin: Why did you go to the Foundation? Can't the Manus give you what you want?

Schneider: Heh heh, of course it's because we, the ones sifted out by the "Storm," want ... to live.

Schneider: The "Storm" is about to fall. Who cares whether the shelter is the eave ... or the rubble?

Schneider: Before finishing her words, Schneider attempts to chop Vertin on the neck with her hand.

Vertin: What if I say, I can provide you with the shelter?

Schneider: ...

Schneider: ...

Schneider: Her hand halts in the air for a second. Yet eventually, she decides to point the pistol toward Vertin.

Schneider: The person who said this to me last time is just sitting behind us watching the game.

Schneider: Pap! Pap!

Thomas: Huh? The trend is falling by 31 points. Is it me or ...?

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Rattenfanger

1ST-13

The Rattenfanger

Underground, The Walden

Sonetto: There is no way ahead. It seems to be another dead end.

Sotheby: Huh? Hmm ... behind this wall, I hear many cheers! This is the exit. It leads to the outside!

Sonetto: There are indeed many voices. Hmm? Timekeeper? I seem to hear her voice!

Sotheby: Hey! Anyone here? Help us please! We're trapped behind the wall!

Sonetto: No. They can not hear us. Let me blast the wall!

Sotheby: No way! It sounds like a banquet outside. A cheerful one! It would be bad if the rubble hit them.

Sotheby: Let me look through the cracks ... Hmm ... It seems we are behind the spotlight.

Sotheby: The cracks are huge! Why don't I use a corrosive potion to dissolve them, so we could move the bricks!

Sonetto: Good idea! Let's start from the middle!

Sonetto: We should get out of here as soon as possible. Timekeeper, she definitely needs my help ...

Schneider: Huh!

Vertin: ...!

Schneider: Ah ha! The joy, the joy from the bottom of my heart ... ♪

Vip Guest: Another 19 points down? What the hell? What are they doing?

Thomas: Can I ... get my 5,000 back? No?

Guest: Hey, Forget Me Not! Is there something wrong with your chart? Today is not April Fools'!

Schneider: Ah ha? What's the matter?

Schneider: Seems no one cares about us anymore, Ms. Governor ...

Schneider: If that is the case ... I will make your arms bleed, my lord. Will the audience be interested then?

Vertin: Ugh!

Vertin: The market is really dropping ahead of time. To accelerate the history like this ... is that for ...

Schneider: Huh! Can't you feel the pain? That's really annoying. Next time if I aim at your thigh, will they be more attracted?

Schneider: Pap!!

Thomas: Damn it! Is it going to f*****g hit the downside? I should've sold it! Go to hell!

Guest: My house! No, my everything! Get my money back! Give it back, you son of a b***h!

Vip Guest: Hello? Darling, no-no I can explain. It's just for the moment. Do you think the Wall Street bankers will just sit around and watch?

Vip Guest: What? Everyone is exiting! The trading volume is more than 12 million shares?!

Thomas: Pay you my ass! Who has the cash? You tell me, who has the cash!

Guest: Let me out! I'm in a hurry. I-I need to go home! I need to go home!

Guest: Pap!

Schneider: Heh heh! Hilarious! I'm killing people but nobody gives a damn!

Schneider: Pap pap! Pap pap!

APPLe: It's too dangerous! Why doesn't Vertin use that blasting Bombard Ball!

Special Action Team Captain: No, not yet! We're fighting up close here, can't let the bomb give us away!

Schneider: Fine. Enough fun for me.

Schneider: If I don't kill you, I'm afraid we won't be able to leave tonight.

Schneider: It would be great if I met you and your "rubble" first, and so we would have not ... Forget it.

Schneider: Ms. Governor, goodbye.

Schneider: She slowly raises the pistol. Her face is as pale and delicate as a sad white pigeon.

Schneider: *lights on*

Schneider: Dazzling spotlights suddenly focus on Vertin and Schneider and blind them.

Sonetto: Timekeeper!

Sonetto: Pap pap pap!

Sonetto: Hurried footsteps are coming toward Vertin.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, what's going on? You are bleeding!

Vertin: I'm fine. Why are you ... behind the stage? You seem well. Thank goodness.

Sotheby: Come here, quick! A lot of people are arguing there. Oh! Careful, you'll be knocked down!

Sotheby: A slow clapping sound comes from the stage away from the fighting ring.

Vertin: Those behind him ... are men of the Manus Vindictae!

Forget Me Not: Thank you all, for giving this about-to-end world such an unforgettable curtain call.

Thomas: Forget Me Not?! I lost all the stocks I bought from you! How will you make up for it!

Forget Me Not: A very good question, dear Mr. Thomas.

Forget Me Not: I am here to share good news with you, comparing with which, the Dow dropping more than 300 is not worth mentioning.

Forget Me Not: The world you live in, year 1929 of the Roaring 20s, is welcoming its finale.

Forget Me Not: And now, I invite you to wait quietly for the finale to come.

Thomas: Are you crazy? Do you know what you're talk ...

Thomas: *casting incantation*

Thomas: Uggh ...

Forget Me Not: Don't worry. He will be quiet for a while.

Forget Me Not: The crowd is no longer noisy.

Forget Me Not: Although the party balloons, the feather decorations, and well-dressed guests still make this place seem a cheerful banquet, the whole room is filled with absolute silence.

Forget Me Not: Silence named "Fear."

Forget Me Not: *phone ringing*

Forget Me Not: Hello? Oh, the Dow closed at ... 230.07. I see.

All Guests: ...

Forget Me Not: That's it, my friends. Wall Street has collapsed.

Forget Me Not: And the "Storm" ...

Forget Me Not: ... has finally come.

Forget Me Not: At first, it's a drop of rain you can barely see.

Forget Me Not: From the drain, from the bottom of rubber shoes, from the milk about to be dumped, they become an unknown pond.

Forget Me Not: Then, the pond becomes the raindrop. It leaves the ground without hesitation, as if trying to get rid of a pernicious habit ...

Forget Me Not: ... a pernicious habit of this era and society.

All Guests: ...

Forget Me Not: What I said caused uproar in the crowd.
And that habit will only grow, like a "mutation," haunting every living body.

Forget Me Not: In the 60s, it crashed people into absurd cartoons. In the 90s, it turns our veins into cables.

Forget Me Not: At last, all the absurdities will transform into a "Storm," and eventually "cleanse" the world.

Forget Me Not: Only the people who weren't sifted out have the right to ...

Forget Me Not: "Reverse," with us.

Vertin: ...

Forget Me Not: These are the details that couldn't be revealed to the public. Our official—Ms. Vertin, you must be familiar with it, right?

Forget Me Not: You know this better than anyone else ... the countdown to the sifting, has already begun.

Vertin: Correct. I finally got the answer.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Prepare for the Ultimate

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Trail ② An Unknown Traveller Ⅱ

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

The Critter in a Coma

小径

On Bankrupt Companies and Newly Registered Companies: February

Public Notice
(1929) IL 17-14000 BD59-3

Great Lakes Media Company, located in Roosevelt Road, the parent company of the Moon Post

of Arcanum, does not possess any distributable assets. The debtors Theodore Jackson (Human), Emilio Robert Henger (Human), and manager Steven Sheridan (Human) have applied for the termination of the bankruptcy proceedings following negotiations.
The Moon Post of Arcanum specializes in reporting news of the arcanist world with a circulation of over 500,000 copies. Renowned articles include Conspiracy: Human Organ Trade and the Witch's Curse. Its parent company Great Lakes Media Company was forced to stop its publication in September 1928 due to anonymous reports to relevant authorities and the emergence of radio stations.
Pursuant to the provisions of The Nelson Act, this Court has reached the verdict of terminating the bankruptcy proceedings of the Great Lakes Media Company in February 14, 1929.
Declared on

February 24, 1929

Public Notice
·List of Newly Registered Companies·

Name: Feldwood Communications Company
Legal Representative: David Clauberg (Human)
Scope of business: Media publishing - Arcanum Global Weekly
Date of establishment: February 3, 1929

Name: Karl Entertainment Publishing Company
Legal representative: Vince Dayne (Human)
Scope of business: Media publishing - American Wizard Entertainments
Date of establishment: February 3, 1929

Name: Coast United Publishing Company
Legal representative: Hugh Midax (Human)
Scope of business: Media publishing - Evening News
Date of establishment: February 5, 1929

.....
Declared on

February 14, 1929

The Eye of the Storm

1ST-14

The Eye of the Storm

Institutum Lorentz Branch

X: That's all for what we know about the "Storm".

X: And what our Institutum does is to catch in advance any time, event, or place that may cause the "Storm."

X: For ourselves we call it—Chaotic Energy.

X: According to the latest research materials, we infer that the "Storm" that could reverse the world was caused by the "Original Butterfly," flapping its wings in the ancient time.

Regulus: The ancient time you said ... is that the oldest of the oldest? Well, the time with no record?

X: I'm afraid it is.

X: The "Butterfly" created the prototype for the prehistoric Chaotic Energy, which became active and unstable through years of accumulation and evolution.

X: Someone took advantage of its instability, and created the "Storm" that could reverse the world.

Regulus: So the circles on your map, are they the markings of where the "Storm" may occur this time?

Regulus: And the mark closest to us ... is now flashing with a red warning light.

X: Yes. Because it's in the eye of the "Storm."

X: In The Walden in Chicago ... where your friends are now.

X: Let us wish her the best of luck.

Walden

Vertin: I finally got the answer.

Vertin: You are using history to expedite the "Storm."

Vertin: Community conflicts, turbulent history, new technology ... all of these may lead to the "Storm."

Vertin: Since the last day of 1999, the world has started to get reversed by the "Storm," one after another.

Vertin: Which past do you want to return? Fifty years ago? A century ago? Or ...

Forget Me Not: The "past" with the right order, of course.

Forget Me Not: Well, I didn't expect the human lackey to understand what the right order is.

Forget Me Not: Friends of The Walden all along, there is not much time for us.

Forget Me Not: Ask yourselves, who will enlighten you of the impending doom but we Manus Vindictae?

Forget Me Not: The last 24 hours in your life, how are you going to spend them?

Forget Me Not: To cry for your no-longer-valuable property? Lie to yourself that all this is not true?

Forget Me Not: Or to take our mission to rebuild the world, extend your lives, until you see the birth of a new order?

Vip Guest: Put on the mask ... and I won't get sifted out by the "Storm"?

Forget Me Not: We will assure the safety of every one of us.

Sonetto: Please do not lie! You actually detained a human in your secret room!

Schneider: ...

Forget Me Not: ...

Forget Me Not: So, your first mission to join us Manus is ...

Forget Me Not: These government lackeys, who hide the truth of the "Storm" from you—take them down.

Vip Guest: ...

Sonetto: Are you really joining this insurgent organization? He is using your fears!

Forget Me Not: Ms. Sonetto, we are scared, but we are free. You know what I am talking about.

APPLe: The rioters are here! Be careful! There are so many of them!

Sotheby: Where are my bodyguards!

Bodyguards: Ms. Sotheby, we are here! We'll have you surrounded, please stay inside!

Sotheby: ... Of course Mr. Karson lied to me.

Sotheby: Fine. It's time to show the power of our manor. Ms. Sonetto, we are here to help!

Special Action Team Captain: Everyone else come with me! Let's break out!

Special Action Team Members: We've been waiting for this moment ...

Special Action Team Members: Let's go!

Choices

1. Don't hurt the innocents. Focus on the Manus!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Poem

小径

Unnamed Poem

Surrounded by imposing barriers,
Epics never sing of those about to die.
Look up, keep looking up,
A broken tile is the only shelter in the tempest.

People always knew how they took the wrong path,
So they regret the unregrettable nights, laugh at the laughable fools.
At the bottom of the cliff, a river always flows.

Trail ① Tuning O' One

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Underground Labyrinth

1ST-15

Underground Labyrinth

A vortex, inside the bar, is whirling.

A vortex full of compressed lips, dull eyes, and irrational words.

Guest: I-I-I'm going home.

The speakeasy is shaking.

Guest: Let me outta here. I don't want any gathering! Screw the money! I'm leaving here ... lu-lunatics!

Guest: The walls are twisting.

Guest: The door ... where's the door? The window? Haha ... did I go crazy too?

Forget Me Not: It's too dangerous outside.

Forget Me Not: Without our masks, you'll soon get infected with the "pernicious habit" of the era, and be sifted out by the "Storm."

Guest: I don't care! I don't give a f**k!

Guest: I can never repay the debt in my lifetime! Aha, let me go before I go insane ...

Guest: You are the government. I-I didn't do anything wrong! I'm begging you, help us!

Sonetto: Don't be afraid. We will definitely ...

Sonetto: Timekeeper ...

Vertin: They've re-constructed the building. All the exits are blocked.

Special Action Team Captain: We got two civilians hurt already!

Special Action Team Captain: There are so many masked civilians among our enemies ... The next battle will be harder!

Vertin: We can't keep fighting like this. We need to find a way out ...

Sotheby: Way out? Oh! Sotheby has got an idea!

Sotheby: Everyone, follow me! The exit is just behind the spotlight on the stage. Hurry up! Don't be left behind!

Bodyguards: We'll protect everyone on both sides! Hey! Stay close if you wanna live!

Guest: Me! Me! Me! Me!

Vertin: The hidden path they just made? ... That may work.

Vertin: Leave four behind for the team! Everyone else move! Don't get caught!

Special Action Team Members: Copy that!

Forget Me Not: Ha ha ha ha!

Forget Me Not: Why would they go underground? There isn't even a window.

Forget Me Not: It gets easier. Think of the time. She'll be back soon.

Underground, The Walden

Sotheby: ...

Sonetto: ...

Sotheby: Hah?

Sotheby: Why is it ... quite different ... from before?

Sotheby: Was the wall in this color just now? I think ... there was a turn at the end ...

Sotheby: Is it ... is it because of the great arcanum?!

Vertin: They've made an underground labyrinth in the speakeasy! The end of the labyrinth, what will that be?

Sonetto: Timekeeper, Sotheby and I have explored here for a while.

Sonetto: The overall area of this secret chamber is not too big, but many obstacles here can move. It's easy to get lost.

Sonetto: I had drawn a map before, and the exit is very close in this direction. As long as it's near the outer wall of the speakeasy, we will be able to break through!

Sotheby: Right! Right! Ms. Sonetto is exceptional!

Vertin: Ok. Then ...

Schneider: Yes. Follow the light.

Schneider: Do not make any noise ... I will meet you soon.

Schneider: ... I'll go get Marian. I think I can find her. She must still be here!

Vertin: ... Is Schneider casting an arcane skill ...?

Vertin: She is near us ... but why can I sense that ...

Sonetto: Timekeeper? Do you ... have any questions about the plan?

Vertin: No, it's nothing. You make the call.

Vertin: There will be many unexpected dangers in the labyrinth. We need to move carefully.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Heaven Apostles · 1/2

1ST-16

Heaven Apostles

APPLe: Not so many forks ahead! We are getting closer to the outer wall.

Vertin: Yes. I heard the sounds of the street.

Bodyguards: Miss Sotheby, did you get hurt? We didn't know there were so many ambushes ...

Sotheby: No worries! You carry Freddy ... ahem ... and clean up the potion on his mouth!

Sonetto: We gathered much intelligence this time. When we get out of here, I will write a report ...

Sonetto: Oh, and ...

Sonetto: Timekeeper, there is another person!

Sonetto: I heard someone asking for help around here! There was also remnants of potion there ...

Sonetto: I want to help her get out.

Vertin: Can you find her position?

Sonetto: Let me think ... it should be around the wall, in front of the critter lair ...

Sonetto: At the end of this corner ... turn right ...

Schneider: Huh! Sis, it's Schneider, call my name ...

Schneider: Don't you remember me? It's Schneider ...

Schneider: Oh, sorry ...

Schneider: I'll get you out right now ... Back to our citrus orchard in Sicily ...

Marian: *vomits*

Schneider: Shh ... be quiet! We will be back home soon.

Schneider: ...

Sonetto: You?!

Sonetto: You chased us here!

Sonetto: It is you! You are abusing this girl ... evil murderer, I must stop you!

Schneider: Don't piss me off. Get lost!

Schneider: Sonetto's arcane skill rushes toward Schneider. Unlike what she used to cast, this one is like a blade made of anger.

Schneider: Uggh ...

Schneider: The girl falls down from Schneider's back. She opens her eyes and rushes to Vertin in panic.

Marian: No! No! I'm not arcanist! I'm not arcanist! I'm not arcanist!!

Marian: I didn't ... won't pretend to be an arcanist ... Oh ... I-I-I can't ... can't drink anymore ...

Vertin: We're here to help. Stay calm, miss.

Marian: She seems to have lost her mind: despite what others say, she just keeps repeating the same incomprehensible words, hands grasping the one in front of her.

Vertin: Uggh ... Let go ...

Schneider: Sis ... don't be like this. You are safe now.

Schneider: What the hell did they force you to eat! F**k!

Sonetto: Huh?!

Sonetto: You are her sister ... I ...

Sonetto: She took the Truth Serum. I have memorized the formula. The feel and smell of the liquid could confirm it.

Sonetto: Let her lie on her back. Right arm high. I will conduct first aid and get her vomit up the potion.

Schneider: ... Ok. Be quick.

The coming sound of footsteps seems more and more oppressive to those who are stranded by this labyrinth.

Schneider: Woosh! Woosh!

Schneider: The whipping sound of vines echoes in the corridor.

APPLe: It is followed by countless footsteps, which implies danger that approaches like a swarm of greedy insects.

APPLe: Oh! We got company! We need to get out of here fast!

Schneider: Schneider stands up.

Schneider: Stay focused. Forget the rest.

Sonetto: Don't worry. Leave it to me.

Sonetto: Just a little more time, she will spit it out ...

Sotheby: Woosh! Woosh! Woosh!

Sotheby: Someone walks toward them leisurely out of the dark.

Sotheby: Her arcane skill has destroyed every inch of the corridor as she approaches.

APPLe: Waffles, the new enemies are not something we can deal with!

Sotheby: Everyone, I found the exit!

Sotheby: This is where we crashed into! As long as we push out the "Auto Island", we can escape from here!

APPLe: Everyone, start pushing now! We have to get out of here!

APPLe: As the enemy approaches from the distance, a group of men in black rush out from another corner.

APPLe: They look around, panic-stricken, and eventually their eyes fall on Schneider.

Man In Black: Is it here? Is the exit here?

Man In Black: Boss! What should we do?

Schneider: Here you are ... The exit is here.

Schneider: Push the car!

Special Action Team Captain: New guys push the hood! Keep pushing! On my mark!

Special Action Team Captain: Ready? Push! Ready? Push!

Sotheby: Oh ... I'm sorry. My "Auto Island" is too strong ... Umm, it's ... it's not moving at all ...

Sotheby: I'm running out of strength ...

Vertin: Mr. APPLe! The "Heaven Apostle"!

APPLe: Oh!

APPLe: Please move out of the way! This is very dangerous!

APPLe: Three rounds left, then right, open the wing, put on the wheel ...

APPLe: Stay away from the car!

Sotheby: Oh ... wow!

APPLe: The car is blasted to the street! Get out of the hole while you can! This wall is about to collapse!

Special Action Team Captain: Run ... I can hold a little longer ...

Sotheby: Four. Five. Six. Quick! We're all out! Just you!

Sonetto: Timekeeper! The wall is falling down!

???: ... Sorry. Please, don't run away.

Vertin: ...!

Vertin: In the blink of an eye, she is now standing in front of them.

Vertin: Judging from her speed of approaching and the range of her arcane skill, it won't make any difference even if all of them manage to escape from the bar.

Vertin: Only four are left inside the wall.

Vertin: Sonetto is trying hard to maintain balance at the exit while carrying Marian on her back.

Sonetto: Timekeeper ... Timekeeper!

Marian: You are ... Schneider, right? Did I ... get away?

Schneider: ...

Schneider: Yes. You made it.

Schneider: You are free now.

Vertin: Go. Run freely.

Vertin: Leave the rest to me.

Vertin: Vertin and Schneider gently push them out of the exit.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: The next moment, the wall has collapsed, blocking the only way out.

???: ...

Schneider: Heh heh ... surprisingly, there's a day ... to fight side by side with you, Ms. Governor.

Vertin: Let's see what a good match we are.

Choices

1. We win, or we die!

How Many Older Sisters Does Schneider Have?

小径

Sounds of different colors go into your left ear and slip out from your nostrils, just like a toboggan sliding down a soft piste from a cabin up the mountain to the finishing line at the foot, leaving nothing but excitement that doesn't even last.

Choices

1. Your opening line sucks.

2. So, a vacation? I'm ready.

Branch 1

Errr ...

What did you say? I, I got bad signal here, oh, ba-bad signal indeed.

I mean, I may be different from all of you, but I have a conscience, OK? I never talk s**t, that's the bottom line. What I said were all felicitous hints.

Branch 2

Yes. You're always so clever, with an excellent sense of humor! Now take all the cold-proof equipment you've got. The view is good here, but it's still dangerous as you are climbing a snow mountain after all.

I'm sure you have noticed it. Between the glacier and the valley, between the snow mountain and the lake, stands a great building we're all familiar with.

Close your eyes and feel the patterns of interlaced gray and white. The flow of the building, so balanced and symmetrical, is like a sophisticated symphony with beautiful melody.

That may be your first impression of the Foundation. After that committee meeting, however, all I could see on your face was a terrible mess, like it was licked by a terrier which has just finished hunting.

What the f**k are they talking about? Who can explain their relations for me?

Good question! In this lonely, whirling, dark universe, I'm the only one who is willing to tell you all these stories on the cold bench in the park.

Choices

1. So what functions does the Foundation have?

2. Who is the boss of the Foundation?

Branch 2.1

Countless! Oh man, you gotta understand, an international political institution with great ambition is bound to make troubles and make up for them.

The House of Integratus and the committee are in charge of lawmaking, not just in the Foundation, but in countries and even in the global society! Any affairs related to the human-arcanist relationship will be brought to their table, and they will handle each of the affairs with their properly manicured but muscle-torn hands.

Through the folds in their brains, people set this reasonable rule: delegates of the House of the Integratus are elected to take responsibility for their constituencies. As busy as bees, they submit countless proposals to the committee every year.

Then the committee will choose one lucky proposal and send it to the next step: all the committee members would gather to debate and vote for the proposal, like what happened in a Medieval Fair.

Many would show up in the fair. There would be political parties, a moderator, dozens of expert groups, each with a different standpoint and goal. It's like a mental boxing, modern version! We will have to wait while listening to the war of words. After dozens of days, or even months, we will finally get to see who wins the championship belt.

Branch 2.2

You haven't met him yet. Actually, only a few have, as the opportunities are always fleeting like the falling stars.

But it's okay. The Foundation still works well without him! Our responsible Constantine, working without any complaint like an unbreakable lily, is trying hard to change the Foundation's direction to what she believes to be correct.

Come on, let's look at the bigger picture. Humans have worked out with the brilliant folds in their brains that they need multiple parties to create a balance of power. So, bang! There come the committee, the House of the Integratus, and many other administration departments.

The House of Integratus and the committee are in charge of lawmaking, not just in the Foundation, but in countries and even in the global society! Any affairs related to the human-arcanist relationship will be brought to their table, and they will handle each of the affairs with their properly manicured but muscle-torn hands.

The committee has the right to approve or reject the proposals from delegates. Well, of course, some of the delegates are very stubborn. They will keep submitting their proposals no matter how many times they have been rejected, just like a red-back shrike with fledglings repeatedly submitting rejected motions until they are exhausted.

When it comes to the formal debate, you will get to watch a dogfight full of polite yet viciously aggressive language. Everyone, including the president, the delegates, the parties and the expert groups, will turn into maniacs in the arena of power.

After this stage, the final result depends on the white marble house. They seldom express their opinions, but they will sometimes.

Choices

1. Are there more?

Oh, yes, yes. Look how polite you are when you ask that question, like I'm some high school student working part-time in a mall selling local socks to you.

And I'd be very nice and tell you, "Of course!" We must not ignore the other administration departments of the Foundation, as well as the headquarters' poor branches located in different countries and the humanitarian School of Primary Defense of Mankind that works like a poorhouse.

Remember, the Foundation is managing the whole world! Of course, they need some rules that are hard to understand, so the wise will be wiser and the silly will be sillier, while those in the middle will show an innocent smile when they die!

Humans are experts on these things. My stupid arcanists, don't just complain; learn to see what they are after, okay? Catch the unspoken drifts between the lines! So one day you will understand ...

Life is like a ride on the toboggan.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Looking Backwards

Heaven Apostles · 2/2

1ST-16

Schneider: Huh ...

Vertin: ...

???: ...

Druvis Ⅲ: ... It's you?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Garden Scissors

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Trail ② The Ignored Nameplate

小径

You are back here again.

Maybe it's telepathy. Maybe your soul is out of your body. Maybe ... Anyway, you're back here. In the dark woods, the huge oak trees crack in front of you. Dry and pungent fumes billow out.

Flames swallow a lot of things: a lot of money, a lot of lives, family laughters, and a pair of eyes that once looked to the future.

Choices

1. What's the smell?

2. It feels like ...

Branch 1

Gasoline. The turf here is tan and shiny. The clump looks like an uneven asphalt road.

After so long, I mean, so many days, probably years, the fumes are still as pungent as yesterday. It won't take eight hours for your eyes to tingle.

There's no boundary for the burned woods. You can hardly tell between the dark night and the scorched woods. To create such a huge, amazing fire ... will a small barrel of gasoline simply be enough?

I'm afraid even 50 barrels are barely enough.

Branch 2

Dead skin. Dead fish. Upturning fishy scales. Desperate, the wailing wails of aquatic animals being boiled in the sea.

Your palm tingles as you caress the trunk. The tree trunks with hanging dried strips of bark look like frightened cats—this might be their last effort to retain their dignity before meeting their doom. The hanging bark falls to the ground at your touch. No muss. No fuss. As if they've prepared for the fall for a long time.

The woods are no fan of the fire. But they don't like staying on the cross for a long time either.

You still have so many questions to ask her.

But before you could, the battle has started.

Choices

1. I still got a chance to ask her.

I like you being positive. Your optimism will help you achieve your goals, get with the impossible girls, pay the bills, and probably become the greatest pacifist!

Oh, did I just mention the girls? Just in case, I need to add a few more, so get with the impossible girls, boys, elders, transgenders, cute radios, ass heads ...

Enough. What we said tonight is just between you and me.

Shared continuation

Looking Backwards